the US credit rating agency Standard & Poor (S & P)—a McGraw Hill Group of Companies.

(ii) *ICRA* (Investment Information and Credit Rating Agency of India Ltd.) was set up in 1991 by IFCI, LIC, SBI and select banks as well as financial institutions to rate debt instruments.

(iii) *CARE* (Credit Analyses and Research Ltd.) was set up in 1993 by IDBI, other financial institutions, nationalised banks and private sector finance companies to rate all types of debt instruments.

(iv) *ONICRA* (Onida Individual Credit Rating Agency of India Ltd.) was set up by ONIDA Finance (a private sector finance company) in 1995 to rate credit-worthiness of non-corporate consumers and their debt instruments i.e. credit cards, hire-purchase, housing finance, rental agreements and bank finance.

(v) *SMERA* (Small and Medium Enterprises Rating Agency) was set up in September 2005, to rate the overall strength of small and medium enterprises (SMEs)—the erstwhile SSIs. It is not a credit rating agency precisely but its ratings are used for this purpose, too. A joint venture of SIDBI (the largest share-holder with 22 per cent stake), SBI, ICICI Bank, Dun & Bradstreet (an international credit information company), five public sector banks (PNB, BOB, BOI, Canara Bank, UBI with 28 per cent stake together) and CIBIL (Credit Information Bureau of India Ltd.).

A general credit rating service not linked to any debt issue is also availed by companies—already offered in India by rating agencies—CRISIL calls such ratings as **Credit Assessment.**[51] International rating agencies such as Moody's, S & P also undertake sovereign ratings i.e. of countries—highly instrumental in external borrowings of the countries.

Individuals are also covered by credit appraisal which is on useful information for the consumer credit firms. To maintain a database on the credit records of individuals the Credit Information Bureau of India Limited (CIBIL) was set up in May 2004 which makes credit informations available to banks and financial institutions about prospective individual borrowers.[52]